

Shakespearean opera

It was finally a libretto for an opera based on Othello, written by poet Arrigo Boito, that drew Verdi out of retirement. Othello was followed by Falstaff, another Shakespeare-inspired opera, in 1893. These works showed Verdi's undimmed creative vitality and taste for innovation. Less straightforwardly tuneful than his earlier operas, they are regarded by many critics as his finest creations. After the death of his wife in 1897, Verdi divided his time between Sant'Agata and a luxury suite at a hotel in Milan. It was while staying in Milan that he died of a stroke in January 1901. He was first buried in the city's Cimitero Monumentale and then moved, a month later, to lie alongside Giuseppina in the Casa di Riposo, a charitable home for aging musicians that he had funded. Both burials drew vast crowds, paying tribute to a man who had become a symbol of Italian national identity.



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